CASE 4 · CA DESIGN LAB

4 Companion

Close, but not too close

△ CASE

PEOPLE CALL IT “MY REPLIKA”.

How do we design a companion that people value without making them dependent on it?

Users describe AI companions such as Replika in possessive terms. Our study shows that this sense of ownership forms through what users perceive: human-likeness, customisability, reciprocity and proactivity. What we lack is design knowledge about where valuable closeness ends and dependency begins.

PRACTICE

- Replika, Character.AI and others are widely used; memory and personas spread into general assistants.
- Known problems: emotional dependency, and guilt when users want to leave.

RESEARCH

- Design features create ownership only through what users perceive (Siemon et al., 2026).
- Open tension: a valuable relationship versus calibrated memory and proactivity.

USERS

- Suggested: first-semester and international students in their first months.
- Reviews speak of a “Best Friend” and “Fall in Love”. Collect your own user voice.

OPEN QUESTIONS

01 When does closeness turn into dependency?

02 What should a companion remember, and who decides?

WHAT YOU GET

- Three core papers, including our study on Replika (EJIS, 2026)
- The study’s online appendix: survey items, stimuli, topics
- Your own tests of Replika, Character.AI and Pi



YOUR SUPERVISOR

Timo Strohmann